

Jinnah's historic speech in the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan on August 11, 1947 and said, "The true exposition of the meaning of secularism can be found in this speech." In a subconscious way, this last conversation with Swamiji was to play a decisive contributory role in my own remarks about Jinnah when I went to Pakistan in May-June 2005." At 20, he would bid goodbye to the city that initiated him into Hindu nationalism; almost a month after Independence, a BOAC propeller aircraft would take him to Delhi. Advani's first yatra began as a refugee. In a partitioned India, there would be more adventurous journeys for the nationalist conditioned by the Sangh and the Swami. (Either of them won't be there to protect him when he returns to have a rendezvous with a secular Jinnah.)

The formation of Bharatiya Jana Sangh by Shyama Prasad Mookerjee, a formidable mind, would mark Advani's formal entry into nationalist politics. "When I look back and ask myself what I learnt from various inspiring sources, the answer I get is this: from the RSS I received my grounding in nationalism and disciplined service of society; Deendayal Upadhyaya inculcated within me great idealism and a realisation of the need for purity and probity in public life; and from Dr Mookerjee I learnt the indispensability of value-based democracy as a vehicle for nation building." Those were the days of idealism. And politics was all about romancing the nation. It was the only rejoinder the nationalists could offer to the Congress. He could afford to be a conviction politician without being reduced to an ideological extremist.

The nationalist's struggle against power reached a critical stage when the totalitarian temptations of Mrs G culminated in the declaration of the Emergency. The imprisonment of Advani and other "enemies of the state" made them the conscience-keepers of a country without justice.

*My Country, My Life* chronicles in anecdotal richness the origin, rise and the inevitable disintegration of the Janata Party, the first effective counterpoint to Congressism. Advani tells the story as witness and participant. The Janata experiment in power was a huge let-down. And the expulsion of Advani and other Jana Sanghis from the Janata and the subsequent formation of BJP set the first notation of bipolarity in Indian politics. The party would, of course, grow beyond Gandhian socialism and integral humanism. It would need displaced gods as electoral allies. Advani, the quintessential organisation man, would semaphore them to the

polling booth. BJP in power owed a great deal to the long-distance traveller of Hindutva.

In the wake of Ayodhya, the memoirist makes a great polemical effort to strike a balance between his individual sadness and the mass Hindu awakening: "A group of kar sevaks delivered their own verdict on some of the seminal questions of Indian history, both medieval and modern. Ram or Babar? Genuine secularism or pseudo-secularism? Justice for all or always appeasement of some? Are Hindus to perpetually remain divided on caste, regional and linguistic lines or should they unite when fundamental challenges confront faith and nationalism? It is not my claim that December 6 answered all these questions in the most satisfactory manner. But it did mark a day of Hindu awakening of truly historic import." No one bothered to listen to his version of the truth then. He had already become a synonym for the savagery of the saffron. Ayodhya was a great hurt; in so many words, he vindicates himself, but without ceasing to be a Hindu who fights for his gods.

Still, the question remains: was BJP in power the happiest moment in his life? The book doesn't provide a definitive answer. And that is not his intention either. Then remember that *My Country, My Life* is the autobiography of a man who has been defined not by power but by his struggle for or against power. That is why Ayodhya and his audacious appraisal of Jinnah are much more engaging than his stint as a cabinet minister. For, BJP-in-power was essentially a Vajpayee moment, in spite of Advani's hard work in mobilisation. His memoirs come to us at a time when he is no longer the proverbial number two but the singular leader of his party—and its prime ministerial candidate. And the man who emerges out of the narrative is a refined reconciler who has the words and the intellectual

means to be a philosopher king. We have not seen him before. Will the allies and grassroots colleagues elsewhere in the states recognise him when he steps out of the pages into the battlefield?

Some political memoirs are projects in mythmaking. This one is a declaration of independence from the mythology of Advani the smiling zealot. One book that transformed his life was Dale Carnegie's *How to Win Friends & Influence People*. Never challenge others in an argument beyond a point, it taught him. With *My Country, My Life*, Advani is certain to win friends and influence India without losing the argument. ■

